The Hoboken Chicken Emergency

By D. Manus Pinkwater

Suggested Roles: ***ACTOR 1:*** *Narrator 1, Mom, Fish Grocer, Professor Mazzocchi, CHICKEN/Henrietta, Dr. Hsu*
ACTOR 2: *Narrator 2, Indian Spice Grocer, Arthur, Radio Newscaster, Mayor, Townspeople 1, 2 and 3*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 5)** This was the first time [Arthur] had the job of getting the Thanksgiving bird, and he had messed it up.

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 2)** Something had gone wrong at Murphy's Meat Market. Somehow Poppa's turkey reservation had gotten lost. Every turkey had some family's name on it – none of them had the name Bobowicz.

MOM: **(Pg 4)** Maybe you'd better go back and get two chickens and a duck. *(smiling)* I'll explain it to your father.

NARRATOR 2: Things had gone even more wrong than Arthur thought. When he got back to Murphy's Meat Market, there wasn't a single chicken in the place –

NARRATOR 1: no ducks either.

NARRATOR 2: He went to every store in town that might possibly have a bird. He went to a few stores that probably did not have birds – just in case.

FISH GROCER: This is a fish market! What makes you think we'd have turkeys or chickens, you silly kid!

INDIAN SPICE GROCER: This is an Indian spice store. Curry powder, we've got; mango chutney, we've got – birds we do not have.

NARRATOR 1: Arthur was getting depressed. He didn't want to go home and tell his mother the bad news, [when] he noticed a card stuck in the window of an apartment house door:

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TOGETHER: *(in amazement and awe)* PROFESSOR MAZZOCCHI / INVENTOR OF THE CHICKEN SYSTEM / BY APPOINTMENT.

NARRATOR 1: Arthur rang the bell.

NARRATOR 2: What did he have to lose?

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *The Hoboken Chicken Emergency by D. Manus Pinkwater*

PROF MAZZOCCHI: *(from off stage - upstairs)* You will not get me evicted! My brother owns this building! I am a scientist! If you people don't stop bothering me, I'll let the rooster loose again.

ARTHUR: *(shouting)* Do you have a chicken for sale? We need one to cook for Thanksgiving.

PROF MAZZOCCHI: What? You want to buy a chicken? Come right up! I have been waiting for years for someone to come to buy a superchicken. The only people who ever come here are neighbors to complain about my chickens. They don't want me to keep them. How much money did you bring?

NARRATOR 1: The old man went inside the apartment with Arthur's sixteen dollars. When he opened the door, Arthur heard a clucking sound, *(Clucking sound)* but not like any clucking he had ever heard -it was deeper, louder. *(Clucking sound again, but deeper and louder)*

PROF MAZZOCCHI: *(returning with a superchicken on a leash)* This is the best poultry bargain on earth - a medium sized superchicken - six cents a pound - here's your two hundred and sixty-six pound chicken, on the hoof. She'll be mighty good eating. Please don't forget to return the leash and collar. *(ushering Arthur out the door and closing it behind him before Arthur can change his mind)*

ARTHUR: *(perplexed and looking from the chicken to the door to the leash and back again – then pounds on the door)*

PROF MAZZOCCHI: *(shouting through the door)* No refunds!

ARTHUR: Don't you have anything smaller?"

PROF MAZZOCCHI: *(shouting through the door)* No refunds!

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NARRATOR 2: The chicken tamely followed Arthur down the stairs as Arthur led it home and tied the leash to the bannister. Then he went in to prepare his mother.

MOM: That took a long time. Did you get a bird?

ARTHUR: I got a chicken. It only cost six cents a pound.

MOM: That's very cheap. Are you sure there's nothing wrong with it. Maybe it isn't fresh.

ARTHUR: It's fresh. It's alive.

MOM: You brought home a live chicken?

ARTHUR: *(starting to cry)* It was the only one I could find. I went to all the stores and nobody had turkeys or chicken or ducks, and finally I bought this chicken from an old man who raises them in his apartment. *(Mom heads for the door)* Momma, it's a very big chicken! *(She opens the door)*

CHICKEN: *(Shifting from foot to foot, blinking)* CLUCK! *(mom closes the door and stands staring at it – long pause)*

MOM: *(in shock)* There's a two-hundred pound chicken in the hall. It's wearing a dog collar.

ARTHUR: I'm supposed to return that. *(Mom opens the door a crack and peeks out, closed the door, looks at Arthur, opens the door all the way and looks out at the chicken.)* I thought we could call her Henrietta.

MOM: Put her in the kitchen and we'll discuss it when you father comes home.

NARRATOR 2: That night the family had meatloaf for Thanksgiving dinner.

NARRATOR 1: [and even better] Poppa decided to let Arthur keep Henrietta.

*******SCENE ********

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 11)** Arthur got up early the day after Thanksgiving. The night before, while Henrietta was sleeping next to his bed, Arthur had made plans to teach her a lot of tricks.

ARTHUR: Henrietta! *(no response – Arthur claps his hands)* – Henrietta! Come here! *(Henrietta looks at him and blinks)* OK, just stay here by yourself *(begins to walk away – Henrietta gallops after him, crashes into him and begins following Arthur around clucking)* Heel, Henrietta, heel, girl.

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NARRATOR 1: She was doing pretty well for a chicken who had never been trained before. Every now and then he would pat Henrietta on the back, and scratch her neck feathers. *(Arthur pantomimes these actions)* She liked that.

NARRATOR 2: [But just then] a door opened to a house across the street and Bozo bounded across the street. Bozo was a big German Shepherd and he ran straight at Arthur and Henrietta!

TRANSITION

ACTOR 1: *To make a long story short . . . Henrietta runs away in a panic and ultimately has to be rescued from a tree by the fire department.*
ACTOR 2: *Unwilling to deal with a giant chicken running wild through the streets, Father makes Arthur return the bird to Professor Mazzocchi.*
ACTOR 1: *Henrietta, feeling unloved and unwanted by anyone, escapes and begins to terrorize the town.*
ACTOR 2: *Arthur knows it is up to him to do something – after all Henrietta was his chicken even if his dad made him give her back.*

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg34)** Arthur arrived outside Professor Mazzocchi's apartment house just in time to see the professor locking the doors of a big green truck. AUGIE'S TRUCK RENTAL, it said on the side. From the muffled clucking and screeching, Arthur could tell that all the professor's experiments were inside.

ARTHUR: Professor Mazzocchi! Are you going away?

PROF MAZZOCCHI: Do you know what happens to people when one of my experiments gets loose? They go crazy! One time they burned down my house! Burned it right to the ground!

ARTHUR: Henrietta is wandering around the streets of Hoboken, all alone. She must be frightened, and cold, and hungry. Don't you care what happens to her?

PROF MAZZOCCHI: Of course I care, but when you've been a mad scientist as long as I have, you learn that some things are more important than others. Most important, right now, is for me to get out of town with all my experiments. If the news gets around that I am responsible for a very large chicken loose in the streets, people will start acting crazy.

NARRATOR 2: Professor Mazzocchi started the engine, and the big green truck rumbled away.

****** SCENE ******

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RADIO NEWSCASTER: **(Pg 46)** AND NOW, A BIZARRE NEWS STORY FROM HOBOKEN, NEW JERSEY . . . LAST NIGHT, MORE THAN FIFTY PEOPLE REPORTED GIANT CHICKEN SIGHTINGS TO THE POLICE, THE F.B.I., AND THE WHITE HOUSE . . . THE CHICKENS, WHICH STAND ABOUT FIFTEEN FEET HIGH, ARE ESTIMATED TO WEIGH ABOUT ONE THOUSAND POUNDS. THERE HAVE BEEN NO REPORTS OF INJURIES, OR ATTACKS ON PERSONS . . . THIS RADIO STATION WILL KEEP YOU POSTED ON THE CHICKEN CRISIS IN HOBOKEN.

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 51)** The whole town was chicken-panicky. The police department's switchboard received thousands of calls from frightened people.

NARRATOR 2: The mayor's office was full of citizens demanding protection from the giant chickens.

NARRATOR 1: Schools were closed. People were afraid to go shopping, to go to work, to step outside their doors.

NARRATOR 2: Special police chicken squads were sent to cruise the streets in cars. Helicopters buzzed over the rooftops, looking for chickens.

NARRATOR 1: Men stayed home from work to protect their families. Neighboring towns sent fire trucks, and teams of veterinarians to help in the chicken emergency.

RADIO NEWSCASTER: THE GIANT CHICKEN WAS SEEN EMERGING FROM THE CLAM BROTHERS SEAFOOD RESTAURANT AT FOUR-FIFTY-SEVEN THIS MORNING. HOBOKEN POLICE OFFICERS SMITH AND MOONEY GAVE CHASE IN THEIR SQUAD CAR, AND CORNERED THE CHICKEN ON COURT STREET, NEAR THIRD. THE CHICKEN THEN KICKED A HUGE DENT IN THE LEFT FRONT FENDER OF THE SQUAD CAR AND RAN OFF.

TRANSITION

ACTOR 1: *For 5 days, Henrietta terrorizes the town: She hijacks a potato chip truck, kicks over a fire-hydrant, and bends the flagpole outside the senior high school.*
ACTOR 2: *Chicken traps are set, but there is no relief from the chicken situation.*
ACTOR 1: *The mayor spent sixty-thousand dollars of the town's money trying to resolve the Hoboken Chicken Emergency and nothing worked.*
ACTOR 2: *Finally, PROF Maz, feeling guilty, sends a specialist to help Hoboken:*
ACTOR 1: *Dr. Hsu, poultry locator, arrives to meet with the Mayor.*

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DR. HSU: **(Pg 72)** Chickens are very sensitive birds. It is very easy to hurt their feelings. When their feelings are hurt, they become unpleasant, anti-social. A perfectly sweet chicken can become a bitter destructive bird, if it feels that it is unwanted.

MAYOR: Do you think Henrietta is a chicken like that? Do you think she feels unwanted, and that's why she's kicking over fire hydrants, and frightening the citizens

DR. HSU: I am sure of it. I have found out that Henrietta was, for a short time, the personal pet of a young boy in this town. His name is Arthur Bobowicz. *(Arthur smiles at the audience and waves)* Young Arthur and Henrietta got to be great friends. Henrietta got into a tiny bit of trouble, and Arthur's parents insisted he take Henrietta back . . . *(Arthur is sad, pantomimes putting the collar and leash on Henrietta and walking her back to Prof. Mazz.)* Henrietta missed Arthur, and set out to look for him. Every time people saw her, they screamed and ran away. *(Actor 2 acts out this out and Dr. HSU responds to the screaming by putting his hands over his ears)* They called the police, and the police chased her. She felt unloved. Think if it happened to you. You'd be angry too. We [have to] encourage the citizens of Hoboken to have a friendly attitude toward chickens. We will ask them to wave and smile when they see Henrietta, instead of screaming, or calling the police, or throwing things at her.

NARRATOR 2: The following day posters were printed. They showed a boy, looking very much like Arthur Bobowicz, with his arm around a big chicken.

NARRATOR 1: The Goodyear blimp was sent for, and it cruised back and forth over Hoboken, towing a large banner which read CHICKENS NEED YOUR LOVE. At night, the message was flashed in electric lights.

NARRATOR 2: The television stations cooperated. There were special panel discussions on the late night talk-shows, in which psychologists and guidance experts told about chickens' need for love and approval. So that they wouldn't upset Henrietta, big white chickens were painted on all the police cars. *(Actor 1 assumes the persona of Henrietta and responds to these townspeople with apprehension that slowly changes to a relaxed co-existance)*

TOWNSPERSON 1: Nice chicken. Nice chicken. *(Henrietta starts to come closer – then runs)*

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TOWNSPERSON 2: Nice Henrietta. Nice chicken. Nobody's going to hurt you. *(Henrietta allows the townsperson to pet her beak)*

TOWNSPERSON 3: Good morning, Henrietta How ya' going? *(Henrietta clucks contentedly and nuzzles the townsperson affectionately)*

NARRATOR 1: [Soon] people couldn't remember why they had been afraid of Henrietta. She seemed to be a very pleasant, well-behaved chicken. They liked her.

TOGETHER: [The Hoboken Chicken Emergency was over]

HENRIETTA: **(Pg 8)** *(Shifting from foot to foot, blinking)* CLUCK!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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